

(Nelson, 2001b). Of course, we try hard to understand what the data say, and, having looked long and carefully at the subtle patterns, we can attempt explanations in a rudimentary form. It is obviously important to identify the attempts as speculative and provisional, but having said that, I would like to describe a picture that appeals to me aesthetically. More general discussion of alternatives and cautions can be found on the GCP Web site.

One way to think of these unexpected correlations is to consider the possibility that the instruments actually have captured the reaction of an inchoate global consciousness. The network was built to do just that: to see whether we could gather evidence for effects of a communal, shared mind in which we are participants even if we don't know it. Groups of people, including the group that is the whole world, have a place in consciousness space, and under special circumstances they—or we—become a stronger presence. Based on experimental evidence that both individuals and groups manifest something suggestive of a consciousness field, the GCP grew out of the hypothesis that there could be a **global consciousness** capable of the same thing. Pursuing this speculation, we could envision an integrated global mind that pays consistent attention to events that inspire strong coherence of attention and feeling among its constituents. Perhaps a useful image is an infant just beginning to develop an integrated awareness, but already manifesting recognizable emotions in response to the enveloping comfort of cuddling or the intense discomfort of pain.

The hypothesis we set out to test is that the REG devices we use may respond to the concerted effect of large numbers of people turning their attention in one direction, becoming deeply absorbed in one focus. There are alternatives to such an explanation of the deviations as an effect of communal consciousness, including that the experimenters themselves might be the source of anomalous effects. This is a viable hypothesis according to professional parapsychologists (White, 1976), and we can accept the possibility that such an "experimenter effect" may contribute to the overall result. The characteristics of the individual events and their correlated outcomes, however, suggest that a broader and more comprehensive source is a major contributor. In the full database of formal and exploratory analyses, there are several instructive parallel cases. For example, my expectation, and that of my colleagues, for the Omagh bombing event in Northern Ireland was exactly the same as for the embassy bombings in Africa. They both were egregious travesties, and they both were the most prominent international news items when they occurred. Yet the results for these two analyses are completely different; one showed a huge effect, the other none at all. The tragedy in Nicaragua in October 1998 from flooding and the collapse of the Casitas volcano showed no response, contrary to our expectations. The bombing in Iraq produced no response, while that in Yugoslavia yielded a highly significant deviation. New Year's Eve, which clearly meets the criteria for global interest as well as the experimenters' expectations, appears to produce quite different results each year, but in the three New Years we have assessed, the data around midnight are nonetheless unmistakably structured, not random.

Either of these models—communal consciousness or experimenter effect—begs for an interaction mechanism. One suggestion is to co-opt the essential qualities of field theory for a “consciousness field” that carries information (Nelson, 1999). This is not completely out of touch with models in physics, and might be formalized in terms of David Bohm’s concept of “active information” (Bohm, 1980). Other efforts to describe a mechanism that could produce the anomalous results in these experiments draw on the “observer” requirements of quantum theory. The idea is that future observation collapses a superposition of possibilities into a state that may represent reality (Schmidt, 1982; Walker, 2000). A recent formalization of this approach argues that no major changes to physical theory are required to address anomalous effects of consciousness (Shoup, 2001b).

The terrible events of September 11 were a powerful magnet for our shared attention. More than any event in recent memory, they evoked extraordinary emotions of horror, fear, commiseration and dismay. The EGG network reacted in a powerful and evocative way. While there are viable alternative explanations, the anomalous correlation is not a mistake or a misreading. It can be interpreted as a clear, if indirect, confirmation of the hypothesis that the eggs’ behavior is affected by global events and our reactions to them. This is startling in scientific terms because we do not have widely accepted models that accommodate such an interpretation of the data. More important than the scientific interpretation, however, may be the question of meaning. What shall we learn, and what should we do in the face of evidence that we may be part of a global consciousness? Of course, this is not a new idea or a novel question. The results from this scientific study are an apparent manifestation of the ancient idea that we are all interconnected, and that what we think and feel has effects everywhere in the world. The discovery of patterns in the GCP data that appear to reflect our shock and dismay implies that these insensate but labile electronic random generators can “see” the effect of massive, shared emotion and attention. The challenges posed by this unexplained effect are great, but it may be an unexpected source of incisive questions about the span of human consciousness.

Conclusion

The GCP is an extension of laboratory REG experiments and non-intentional FieldREG experiments to a much larger domain, using a network of REG sampling nodes distributed around the world. The data from multiple, independent devices running in parallel, continuously over months and years, can be a rich resource for a variety of purposes, including correlation with special moments in time, as described in this article. It also may be instructive to attempt correlations with other variables, such as the geophysical and cosmological data that have shown some promise in psychophysiological and